

WITHOUT COVER
Despite a fine for not wearing masks being reimposed, people go about without it at old Delhi's Sadar Bazaar

recorded an uptick, among them Kerala, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Bengal, Punjab and Uttarakhand. Three states—Delhi, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh—emerged as areas of particular concern, as they account for 68 per cent of the cases reported last week. Delhi itself has seen 9,684 fresh cases, a substantial 53 per cent more than those recorded in the week ending April 24, and had an r-value estimate of 2 in the week ending April 18. Having dropped mandatory mask usage in public on April 2, the national capital had to quickly reinstate the rule within 20 days as cases began to multiply. "This virus is here to stay and will keep coming back," says Dr Vivek Nangia, head of the pulmonology department at the Max hospital in Saket, Delhi. "We need to remain on alert, and not let our guard down till the pandemic is over. The threat of a new variant still cannot be ruled out," says Dr Rahul Pandit, member of the Maharashtra's task force on Covid.

> "(The new antiviral drug Paxlovid) is for those at high risk, and displaying mild to moderate symptoms. **Its efficacy is quite good against Omicron."**
>
> **– DR ANKITA BAIDYA,** *Infectious diseases specialist*

Are we, then, poised at the start of a new wave? Government officials are quick to reassure us that the current crop of cases do not signify one. Samiran Panda, additional director general of ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research), dubs it a "blip", or localised surges at district levels. He also points to the absence of any increase in hospital admission rates or signs of a new variant. "One should be vigilant against Covid," says AIIMS director Dr Randeep Guleria, "but not panic. The areas seeing a surge should make an extra effort to contain transmission." It was this sharp focus that experts say helped India dilute the effects of the last Omicron wave.

"We are far better prepared for the virus now," says Dr Pandit. "Not only in terms of medicine, infrastructure, but equally awareness."

THREE T'S AND THE VACCINE

India is continuing with its strategy of test-track-treat-vaccinate and observ-